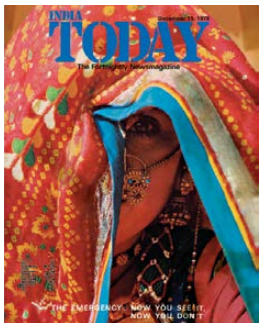
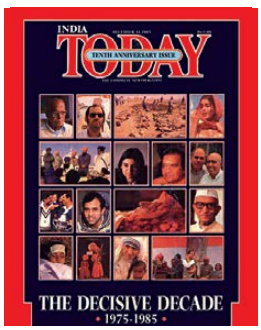
TODAY too turned weekly in 1997, because India itself was moving faster.

The restlessness of the new millennium deepened both promise and tension. During the decade-long rule of the United Progressive Alliance (UPA), high growth imperatives blended with a new social conscience. As prime minister, Manmohan Singh steered India through the global financial crisis with calm and foresight. At the same time, his government lifted millions out of poverty and expanded the social contract through rights-based legislations such as the right to information, education, employment and food security, with Sonia often seen as their initiator. Yet, coalition constraints, policy paralysis and corruption scandals eroded public confidence and, by the early 2010s, fatigue had set in. Not with democracy itself, but with the drift that the UPA had come to symbolise.

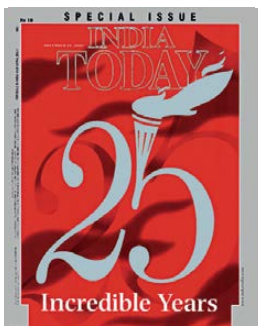
That produced a decisive political turn, with Modi's rise reconfiguring power: a majority government had returned after a quarter century. Modi proved to be a charismatic leader with many avatars all at once: welfarist, reformer, warrior, visionary builder and, with the inauguration of the Ram Mandir, the harbinger of a new Hindu assertion. Major constitutional changes such as the abolition of Article 370, rapid infrastructure expansion and state-of-the-art digital governance reshaped India even as Prime Minister Modi responded militarily to terror attacks and projected a confident India abroad. The COVID-19 pandemic tested governance at an unprecedented scale, revealing both resilience and fault lines. Through it all, India displayed its characteristic capacity to improvise, endure and argue with itself. Running alongside these political shifts were parallel transformations. There were new self-made wealth creators, new conversations around gender and sexuality, frightening damage to the environment, trends in health, lifestyle and celebrity culture. Faith, commerce, technology, geopolitics and identity intersected in new, often uneasy ways. We chronicled them all.



Dec. 15, 1975



Dec. 31, 1985



Dec. 25, 2000



Dec. 27, 2010



Dec. 21, 2015

Looking back across these five decades, patterns emerge. India repeatedly swings between centralisation and diffusion, between idealism and pragmatism, between assertion and dissent. While everything seemed to have changed, in one sense nothing had really changed, with the key issues such as caste, religion, federalism and centralisation continuing to dominate our discourse. Yet, each era brought its moments of grace: democratic renewal, economic liberation, technological leaps, rising global stature. And its own anxieties: violence, exclusion, inequality, polarisation. The Republic has survived not because it avoided these tensions and contradictions, but because it absorbed them and continuously reinvented itself.

As India steps into a future shaped by artificial intelligence, climate stress, demographic change and a fractious global order, certainty will be scarce. But our commitment remains clear. We will continue to chronicle India in the present tense and with the same rigour, curiosity, integrity and passion for editorial excellence. That is the leitmotif of INDIA TODAY and the larger India Today Group. It has guided us for 50 years, and it will guide us still. India is a restless, aspirational, argumentative, inventive, democratic nation with a life-force of its own. It is a pleasure and a privilege to hold a mirror to it. Happy 50th anniversary.



(Aroon Purie)